mandatory for any white child in the sun, and the elephant retrieving it from the forest floor and handing it back to me with his trunk, ever so delicately. I have loved these gentle, intelligent giants ever since, and fully understand why the early Buddhists and Emperor Ashoka in particular chose the elephant as a symbol of their faith. I used to be puzzled as to why Hinduism did not follow suit and why the cow was preferred. Now I know better, as a later chapter explains.

Three other particularly vivid images from my Indian childhood have stayed with me. One is of my father dispensing justice on the front verandah of our bungalow. He was then a Political Officer in the North-East Frontier Agency, where he had responsibility for maintaining law and order among the hill tribes bordering India's frontier with Tibet. It was customary for officials like him to make themselves available outside office hours to all and sundry, and this is what I remember him doing, morning and evening, on the verandah, so that there were always queues of people – many of them wild-looking men in rudimentary loincloths armed with bows, spears and short swords – waiting for him to hear their petitions or resolve their quarrels. It left me with a lasting image of my father as the very embodiment of British rule in India, which I grew up believing to be essentially benevolent, even if paternalist. Apparently a majority of British people share those same early views of mine, since a recent YouGov poll found that 43 per cent of the British public are generally proud of colonialism and the British empire, and only 21 per cent regret that it happened.[1]

A second memory comes from that same bungalow. When I was about four my parents went to Calcutta (now Kolkata), leaving me in the care of my father's boss, who was a bachelor. I had a slight fever, which was why I was lying on my bed in the middle of the afternoon. I heard a hiss, and there on the floor by the door was a large cobra. I screamed